> "THE SPARTANS MARCHED SLOWLY AND TO THE MUSIC OF MANY PIPERS IN THEIR RANKS … SO THAT THE MEN COULD CLOSE ON THE ENEMY STEADILY AND EVENLY AND NOT FALL OUT OF FORMATION."
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> **THUCYDIDES**, DESCRIBING SPARTANS AT THE FIRST BATTLE OF MANTINEA, 418 BCE, PELOPONNESIAN WAR

with his shield hooked over his left forearm and a spear held in his right hand – was an intimidating sight. The Spartans initiated the custom of singing a "paean", or war song, as they marched forward, a habit eventually adopted by most Greek forces. Singing helped men to cope with the desperate feeling of vulnerability as the shock of collision with the enemy approached. The Greek historian Thucydides recorded how an advancing phalanx tended to drift to the right, since "fear makes every man want to do his best to find protection for his unarmed side in the shield of the man next to him on the right, thinking that the more closely the shields are locked together, the safer he will be." There was always a risk of losing the tight phalanx formation. Greek writer Xenophon described an occasion when "part of the phalanx surged forward in front of the rest and the part that was left behind began to advance at the double" to catch up.

At a certain distance from the enemy, the hoplites would break into a run, charging forward while emitting a high-pitched war cry. Then the two phalanxes clashed shield to shield, the hoplites in the front ranks thrusting with their spears through the gaps in the enemy shield wall. At some point in this struggle one part of a phalanx would collapse under the pressure of the attack. As the formation broke up and men attempted to flee the field, the defeated side could expect to suffer heavy casualties. It seems that losses on the winning side were typically around five per cent – including a relatively high percentage of the hoplites in the front lines, the men actively engaged in the fighting. On the losing side, casualties would probably mount to around 15 per cent of the soldiers in the field, many being butchered as they fled.

FIGHTING THE PERSIANS

The fighting qualities of the Greek hoplite were put thoroughly to the test when large Persian armies invaded Greece, first in 490 BCE and then again a decade later. On the first occasion a predominantly Athenian force clashed with a far larger Persian army, including cavalry, at Marathon. Despite their inferior numbers, the hoplites charged the Persian lines.



Greek warrior
This stylized figurine shows a hoplite with a crested helmet and a round shield. Hoplites dressed and fought in much the same way across all the small city-states of the Greek world.

Respite from war
During the Olympic Games, a pan-Hellenic festival held every four years, hostilities between warring cities were normally suspended. One of the best-preserved sites at Olympia is the *palestra* or gym where the athletes trained.

